

READINGS FOR THE WEEK OF PRAYER
DECEMBER 6 - 14, 2024

Praying Always

Ephesians 6:18

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Content



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Introduction

Dear brothers and sisters in the Lord, we greet you with the counsel of the holy word: "Pray without ceasing." 1 Thessalonians 5:17.

The apostle Paul's words are both significant and absolute. First, he invites us to pray. Prayer is the act of talking to God. When we pray, we converse with the Father and express our feelings, struggles, desires, and emotions. In short, we open our hearts to Him. What a great privilege! Every son and daughter of God is compelled to go to the throne of grace. Jesus expressed this thought when He said, "Ask, and it shall be given you;..."

It is imperative that we ask God for what we desire to receive from Him. Christ ended His teaching on this subject in the sermon on the mount by saying, "... How much more shall your Father which is in heaven give good things to them that ask Him?" Matthew 7:7, 11. It is not possible to receive something from God if we do not desire it, and much less if we do not ask for it. It is true that everyone (including the atheist) receives many things from above without asking for them, such as the gift of life, the air one breathes, the sun that warms the earth, and the food that comes from the land. But some aspects of life can be changed or made better only if one asks God, the Creator of life, for them.

Think about this: What would have happened in Egypt during the seven-year famine if Joseph had not become prime minister? Or what if Daniel and his three companions had not been in the Babylonian court among the wise men? They and many other Biblical characters were men of faith and prayer. Joseph was despised and sold into slavery by his brothers. Had he not been sustained by prayer, he would have been overwhelmed by the circumstances that he passed through. If Daniel, as King Nebuchadnezzar's servant, had not cultivated prayer, God would never have been able to tell him the king's dream and its interpretation. The monarch was impressed by the prophet's fidelity and character; and after making a unique experience with God, the king extolled and honored Him in his last recorded words. Daniel 4:37.

The most outstanding example of prayer in all of the Scriptures is our Lord and Saviour, Jesus Christ. Prayer to His Father was the oxygen that sustained Him. Prayer was not just an option but was the sustenance of His soul. He knew that the salvation of humanity depended on such prayer, which is both simple and foundational. Sadly, most people neglect it. That is why the words about Jesus are so significant: "And continued all night in prayer to God." Luke 6:12.

The redemption of every human being depended on Christ's obedience to the holy law. This would not have been possible in His human incarnation if He had not had such a

complete relationship with His Father. And the same is true for us. It is not possible to live a victorious life without cultivating the habit of prayer, as the inspired pen declared: "If we would develop a character which God can accept, we must form correct habits in our religious life. Daily prayer is as essential to growth in grace, and even to spiritual life itself, as is temporal food to physical well-being." –*Messages to Young People*, p. 114.

The first word of the theme for this Week of Prayer is in the ongoing form—"Praying." But it is more, for prayer is a divine command. God knows that we need to receive the presence of the Holy Spirit if we are to win the battles of the soul and be victorious over every temptation that the enemy presents. Therefore, if we are sincere, we will recognize that the enemy's primary objective is for every son and daughter of God to neglect prayer; and we all know how easy this is today when we are surrounded by so many distractions.

The second important concept in the words of the apostle Paul is "always." It is not sporadic prayer that makes it possible for us to build our houses on the rock and defeat the enemy when he comes to tempt us in the desert of our lives in this world.

Dear brothers and sisters, each of the Readings in this Week of Prayer invites us to seek the face of God in prayer. Let the meetings during this dedicated time be well organized in every church, home, and online. The last Sabbath will be dedicated to fasting, prayer, and giving. The final reading will be presented as a sermon during the service, followed by the gathering of the special offering for the General Conference to open and support new mission fields. Everyone is requested to write on the envelope containing his offering a Bible verse that expresses his spiritual desires and gratitude. Let us do everything we can during these days to meet with our brothers and sisters for the readings.

With all our hearts, we pray to our heavenly Father to strengthen us more and more and prepare us for the conflicts that we have now and that we will face in the days ahead. Amen.

—*Brothers and sisters of the General Conference*

PRAY WITHOUT CEASING

Ellen G. White



WOP 2024 – "Praying Always"

Daily prayer is as essential to growth in grace, and even to spiritual life itself, as is temporal food to physical well-being. We should accustom ourselves to often lift the thoughts to God in prayer. If the mind wanders, we must bring it back; by persevering effort, habit will finally make it easy. We cannot for one moment separate ourselves from Christ with safety. We may have His presence to attend us at every step, but only by observing the conditions which He has Himself laid down. –*Messages to Young People*, p. 115.

Although Christ had given the promise to His disciples that they should receive the Holy Spirit, this did not remove the necessity of prayer. They prayed all the more earnestly; they continued in prayer with one accord. Those who are now engaged in the solemn work of preparing a people for the coming of the Lord, should also continue in prayer. –*Gospel Workers*, p. 371.

They [Jesus' disciples] had not heeded the repeated warning, "Watch and pray." At first they had been much troubled to see their Master, usually so calm and dignified, wrestling with a sorrow that was beyond comprehension. They had prayed as they heard the strong cries of the sufferer. They did not intend to forsake their Lord, but they seemed paralyzed by a stupor which they might have shaken off if they had continued pleading with God. They did not realize the necessity of watchfulness and earnest prayer in order to withstand temptation. –*The Desire of Ages*, p. 688.

The experience of the disciples in the Garden of Gethsemane contains a lesson for the Lord's people today.... They did not realize the necessity of watchfulness and earnest prayer in order to withstand temptation. Many today are fast asleep, as were the disciples. They are not watch-

ing and praying lest they enter into temptation. Let us often read and give careful study to those portions of God's word that have special reference to these last days, pointing out the dangers that will threaten God's people. –*In Heavenly Places*, p. 97.

Prayer is the life of the soul

Prayer is a necessity; for it is the life of the soul. Family prayer, public prayer, have their place; but it is secret communion with God that sustains the soul life. –*Education*, p. 258.

Several times each day precious, golden moments should be consecrated to prayer and the study of the Scriptures, if it is only to commit a text to memory, that spiritual life may exist in the soul. The varied interests of the cause furnish us with food for reflection and inspiration for our prayers. Communion with God

is highly essential for spiritual health, and here only may be obtained that wisdom and correct judgment so necessary in the performance of every duty. —*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 4, p. 459.

If those who sound the solemn notes of warning for this time could realize their accountability to God, they would see the necessity for fervent prayer. When the cities were hushed in midnight slumber, when every man had gone to his own house, Christ, our example, would repair to the Mount of Olives, and there, amid the overshadowing trees, would spend the entire night in prayer. He who was Himself without the taint of sin—a treasure house of blessing; whose voice was heard in the fourth watch of the night by the terrified disciples upon the stormy sea, in heavenly benediction; and whose word could summon the dead from their graves—He it was who made supplication with strong crying and tears. He prayed not for Himself, but for those whom He came to save. As He became a suppliant, seeking at the hand of His Father fresh supplies of strength, and coming forth refreshed and invigorated as man's substitute, He identified Himself with suffering humanity, and gave them an example of the necessity of prayer. His nature was without the taint of sin.

As the Son of man, He prayed to the Father, showing that human nature requires all the divine support which man can obtain that he may be braced for duty and prepared for trial. As the Prince of Life, He had power with God, and prevailed for His people. This Saviour, who prayed for those that felt no need of prayer, and wept for those that felt no need of tears, is now before the throne, to receive and present to His Father the petitions of those

for whom He prayed on earth. The example of Christ is for us to follow. Prayer is a necessity in our labor for the salvation of souls. God alone can give the increase of the seed we sow. —*Gospel Workers*, pp. 28, 29.

Spiritual progress depends on prayer

If there were more praying among us, more exercise of a living faith, and less dependence upon someone else to have an experience for us, we would be far in advance of where we are today in spiritual intelligence. What we need is a deep, individual heart and soul experience. Then we shall be able to tell what God is doing and how He is working. We need to have a living experience in the things of God; and we are not safe unless we have this. There are some who have a good experience, and they tell you about it; but when you come to weigh it up, you see that it is not a correct experience, for it is not in accordance with a plain Thus saith the Lord. If ever there was a time in our history when we needed to humble our individual souls before God, it is today. We need to come to God with faith in all that is promised in the word, and then walk in all the light and power that God gives. —*Review and Herald*, July 1, 1909.

"Religion must begin with emptying and purifying the heart, and must be nurtured by daily prayer".

—*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 4, p. 535.

It is just as convenient, just as essential, for us to pray three times a day as it was for Daniel. Prayer is the life of the soul, the foundation of spiritual growth. In your home, before your family, and before your workmen, you should testify to this truth. And when you are privileged to meet with your brethren in the church, tell them of the necessity of keeping open the channel of communication between God and the soul. Tell them that if they will find heart and voice to pray, God will find answers to their prayers. Tell them not to neglect their religious duties. Exhort the brethren to pray. We must seek if we would find, we must ask if we would receive, we must knock if we would have the door opened unto us. —*Signs of the Times*, February 10, 1890.

In the service of the Jewish priesthood we are continually reminded of the sacrifice and intercession of Christ. All who come to Christ today are to remember that His merit is the incense that mingles with the prayers of those who repent of their sins and receive pardon and mercy and grace. Our need of Christ's intercession is constant. Day by day, morning and evening, the humble heart needs to offer up prayers to which will be returned answers of grace and peace and joy. "By Him therefore let us offer the sacrifice of praise to God continually, that is, the fruit of our lips giving thanks to His name. But to do good and to communicate forget not: for with such sacrifice God is well pleased." Hebrews 13:15, 16. —*Seventh-day Adventist Bible Commentary*, vol. 6, p. 1078.

From every Christian home a holy light should shine forth. Love should be revealed in action. It should flow out in all home intercourse, showing itself in thoughtful kindness, in gentle, unself-

ish courtesy. There are homes where this principle is carried out—homes where God is worshiped and truest love reigns. From these homes morning and evening prayer ascends to God as sweet incense, and His mercies and blessings descend upon the suppliants like the morning dew. —*Patriarchs and Prophets*, p. 144.

In following Christ, looking unto Him who is the Author and Finisher of your faith, you will feel that you are working under His eye, that you are influenced by His presence, and that He knows your motives. At every step you will humbly inquire: Will this please Jesus? Will it glorify God? Morning and evening your earnest prayers should ascend to God for His blessing and guidance. True prayer takes hold upon Omnipotence and gives us the victory. Upon his knees the Christian obtains strength to resist temptation. —*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 4, pp. 615, 616.

Prayer connects the soul to heaven

Those who will put on the whole armor of God and devote some time every day to meditation and prayer and to the study of the Scriptures will be connected with heaven and will have a saving, transforming influence upon those around them. Great thoughts, noble aspirations, clear perceptions of truth and duty to God, will be theirs. They will be yearning for purity, for light, for love, for all the graces of heavenly birth. Their earnest prayers will enter into that within the veil. This class will have a sanctified boldness to come into the presence of the Infinite One. They will feel that heaven's light and glories are for them, and they will become refined, elevated, ennobled by this intimate ac-

quaintance with God. Such is the privilege of true Christians. —*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 5, pp. 112, 113.

Consecrate yourself to God in the morning; make this your very first work. Let your prayer be, “Take me, O Lord, as wholly Thine. I lay all my plans at Thy feet. Use me today in Thy service. Abide with me, and let all my work be wrought in Thee.” This is a daily matter. Each morning consecrate yourself to God for that day. Surrender all your plans to Him, to be carried out or given up as His providence shall indicate. Thus day by day you may be giving your life into the hands of God, and thus your life will be molded more and more after the life of Christ. —*Steps to Christ*, p. 70.

The very first out-breathing of the soul in the morning should be for the presence of Jesus. “Without Me,” He says, “ye can do nothing.” It is Jesus that we need; His light, His life, His spirit, must be ours continually. We need Him every hour. And we should pray in the morning that as the sun illuminates the landscape, and fills the world with light, so the Sun of Righteousness may shine into the chambers of mind and heart, and make us all light in the Lord. We cannot do without His presence one moment. The enemy knows when we undertake to do without our Lord, and he is there, ready to fill our minds with his evil suggestions that we may fall from our steadfastness; but it is the desire of the Lord that from moment to moment we should abide in Him, and thus be complete in Him. —*My Life Today*, p. 15.

Nothing tends more to promote health of body and of soul than does a spirit of gratitude and praise. It is a positive duty to resist melancholy, discontented thoughts and feelings—as much

a duty as it is to pray. —*The Ministry of Healing*, p. 251.

We must be much in prayer if we would make progress in the divine life. When the message of truth was first proclaimed, how much we prayed. How often was the voice of intercession heard in the chamber, in the barn, in the orchard, or the grove. Frequently we spent hours in earnest prayer, two or three together claiming the promise; often the sound of weeping was heard and then the voice of thanksgiving and the song of praise. Now the day of God is nearer than when we first believed, and we should be more earnest, more zealous and fervent, than in those early days. Our perils are greater now than then. Souls are more hardened. We need now to be imbued with the spirit of Christ, and we should not rest until we receive it.

Our prayers should be full of tenderness and love. When we yearn for a deeper, broader realization of the Saviour's love, we shall cry to God for more wisdom. If ever there was a need of soul-stirring prayers and sermons, it is now. The end of all things is at hand. O that we could see as we should the necessity of seeking the Lord with all the heart! Then we should find Him. May God teach His people how to pray. —*God's Amazing Grace*, p. 92.

“Prayer is a necessity; for it is the life of the soul. Family prayer, public prayer, have their place; but is secret communion with God that sustains the soul life.”

—*Education*, p. 258.

JESUS AND PRAYER

Humberto Avellaneda, Colombia / U.S.A.

“**A**nd it came to pass, that, as He was praying in a certain place, when He ceased, one of His disciples said unto Him, Lord, teach us to pray, as John also taught his disciples.” Luke 11:1.

Why did His disciples ask Jesus to teach them how to pray? Could it be that they did not know how to pray or did not do it well? They witnessed Jesus pray and wanted to pray as He did. This should be our constant request, especially during this Week of Prayer: “Lord, teach us to pray.”

For the Jews, prayer was an integral part of life and worship. Numerous prayers appear in the book of Psalms and elsewhere in the Hebrew Scriptures. It was not something that was unknown to the disciples. They knew the ceremonial prayers of the Jewish religious leaders. But as they observed Jesus, they realized that there was a great difference between the rabbis’ prayers and those of Jesus, which motivat-

ed them to make that request, “Lord, teach us to pray.” Jesus is our Example in prayer, for it was an important part of His ministry. He prayed very early in the morning when it was still dark, during the day, and on many occasions throughout the entire night. What an excellent example for us! Furthermore, His prayers differed from those that the disciples were used to hearing.

“Christ’s disciples were much impressed by His prayers and by His habit of communion with God. One day after a short absence from their Lord, they found Him absorbed in supplication. Seemingly unconscious of their presence, He continued praying aloud. The hearts of the disciples were deeply moved. As He ceased praying, they exclaimed, ‘Lord, teach us to pray.’” –*Review and Herald*, August 11, 1910.

Dear brothers and sisters, the Saviour’s earthly life was a one of communion with His Father, of

prayer. It was an example for us, for He revealed the secret of a powerful life. Let us look at some essential aspects of Jesus and prayer.

Jesus prayed for strength to endure trial

Jesus, the Son of Man, prayed to His Father, showing us that the human being requires every divine support to be strengthened for duty and trial. “Few are willing to imitate His amazing privations, to endure His sufferings and persecutions, and to share His exhausting labor to bring others to the light.... Christ is the Captain of our salvation, and by His own sufferings and sacrifice He has given an example to all His followers that watchfulness and prayer, and persevering effort, were necessary on their part if they would rightly represent the love which dwelt in His bosom for the fallen race.” –*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 2, p. 664.

“When Jesus was led into the wilderness to be tempted, He was led by the Spirit of God. He did not invite temptation. He went to the wilderness to be alone, to contemplate His mission and work. By fasting and prayer He was to brace Himself for the bloodstained path He was to travel. How should He begin His work of freeing the captives held in torment by the destroyer? During His long fast, the whole plan of His work as man’s deliverer was laid out before Him.” –*Selected Messages*, book 1, p. 227.

“The night seasons of prayer which the Saviour spent in the mountain or in the desert were essential to prepare Him for the trials He must meet in the days to follow. He felt the need of the refreshing and invigorating of soul and body, that He might meet the temptations of Satan; and those who are striving to live His life will feel this same need.” –*Maranatha*, p. 85.

Jesus prayed to prepare for particular tasks

Here is a fascinating matter from Jesus’ prayer life to consider: We all make important decisions in our daily lives—at home, at church, at work, and elsewhere. The question is: How much time do we dedicate to prayer before making these decisions or carrying out our work?

As we have seen, when Jesus was about to begin His ministry, according to the Scriptures, the Holy Spirit led Him into the desert. There he dedicated forty days to fasting and prayer for strength for the critical, challenging mission that lay ahead of Him. But that was not the only occasion when the Lord Jesus spent extra time in prayer; He also prayed before beginning a vital work. “And it came to pass in those days, that

He went out into a mountain to pray, and continued all night in prayer to God. And when it was day, He called unto Him His disciples; and of them He chose twelve, whom also He named apostles.” Luke 6:12, 13.

This story catches my attention when it says, “and continued all night in prayer to God.” The verse does not say, “and He spent a few minutes in prayer,” or “He took a few moments to pray.” No, He spent the whole night in prayer. The next day, He would dedicate the twelve, and He wanted to make a good choice. The question, dear brother and dear sister, is: When did you last spend all night in communion with God? Or perhaps an hour in prayer? How about the day when you were going to choose your wife or husband, or when you decided to be baptized? Today, we are talking about Jesus and prayer. How much we should learn from our Master!

“Jesus, when preparing for some great trial or some important work, would resort to the solitude of the mountains and spend the night in prayer to His Father. A night of prayer preceded the ordination of the apostles and the sermon on the mount, the transfiguration, the agony of the judgment hall and the cross, and the resurrection glory.” –*The Ministry of Healing*, p. 509.

“After His work was finished for the day, He went forth, evening after evening, away from the confusion of the city, and His form was bowed in some retired grove in supplication to His Father. At times the bright beams of the moon shone upon His bowed form. And then again the clouds and darkness shut away all light. The dew and frost of night rested upon His head and beard while in the attitude of a suppliant. He frequently continued His pe-

titions through the entire night. He is our example. If we could remember this, and imitate Him, we would be much stronger in God.” –*Prayer*, p. 174.

Jesus had special places to pray

In discussing a unique place for prayer, I remember in missionary school that I had a place in the forest where I liked to go and pray at night. It was quite interesting, because I could talk alone with God, cry and pour out my soul, and tell Jesus everything. Sometimes when I arrived at that place, a fellow student had preceded me, and he was praying there. We would then pray together.

The Lord Jesus also had selected places where He prayed; when the disciples wanted to meet with their Teacher, they knew where to look for Him.

“And in the morning, rising up a great while before day, He went out, and departed into a solitary place, and there prayed. And Simon and they that were with him followed after Him. And when they had found Him, they said unto Him, All men seek for Thee.” Mark 1:35-37.

The text speaks of His retiring to desert places. That is, Jesus sought out places that were appropriate and solitary so that He would be able to come close to His Father.

“And when He had sent the multitudes away, He went up into a mountain apart to pray; and when the evening was come, He was there alone.”

Matthew 14:23.

"And He came out, and went, as He was wont, to the mount of Olives; and His disciples also followed Him. And when He was at the place, He said unto them, Pray that ye enter not into temptation. And He was withdrawn from them about a stone's cast, and kneeled down, and prayed." Luke 22:39-41.

"Have a place for secret prayer. Jesus had select places for communion with God, and so should we. We need often to retire to some spot, however humble, where we can be alone with God." –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 84.

When working as a Bible worker in my country, I visited a small town where a couple of elderly pioneers of the church lived and where a room in the house caught my attention. It was very nicely arranged with a table, a few chairs, and some posters bearing Bible verses. This was their place of prayer. Three times a day, in the morning, at noon, and in the evening, they went there to pray. If anyone was visiting them at that time, they invited him to join them there, and they did not use that place for anything else. Nothing other than the Bible was discussed in that place, and that made a deep impression on me to this day. How important it is, dear brothers, sisters, and friends, for us to have a special place for prayer, a place to talk to God, and a place for us to listen to Him every day.

The men and women who came to reflect the character of Christ and who have been an excellent example for the world spent a lot of time with God, so much so that this habit was a notable part of their lives.

Martin Luther expressed his experience like this: "If one fails to spend two hours in prayer each morning, the enemy will

gain the victory during the day. I have many matters that I cannot handle without spending three hours a day in prayer." His saying was: "He who has prayed well has studied well."

"The darkness of the evil one encloses those who neglect to pray. The whispered temptations of the enemy entice them to sin; and it is all because they do not make use of the privileges that God has given them in the divine appointment of prayer. Why should the sons and daughters of God be reluctant to pray, when prayer is the key in the hand of faith to unlock heaven's storehouse, where are treasured the boundless resources of Omnipotence?" –*Steps to Christ*, p. 94.

"If those who sound the solemn notes of warning for this time could realize their accountability to God, they would see the necessity for fervent prayer. When the cities were hushed in midnight slumber, when every man had gone to his own house, Christ, our example, would repair to the Mount of Olives, and there, amid the overshadowing trees, would spend the entire night in prayer....

"As the human was upon Him, He felt His need of strength from His Father. He had select places of prayer. He loved to hold communion with His Father in the solitude of the mountain. In this exercise His holy, human soul was strengthened for the duties and trials of the day." –*Prayer*, pp. 18, 173.

Jesus prayed for others

The Lord Jesus continually received power from above to meet men. Scriptures tell us: "... And the word which ye hear is not Mine, but the Father's which sent Me." John 14:24. Thus, He received words of salvation to impart to others every day.

"For even the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give His life a ransom for many." Mark 10:45.

"Not for Himself, but for others, He lived and thought and prayed. From hours spent with God He came forth morning by morning, to bring the light of heaven to men. Daily He received a fresh baptism of the Holy Spirit. In the early hours of the new day the Lord awakened Him from His slumbers, and His soul and His lips were anointed with grace, that He might impart to others. His words were given Him fresh from the heavenly courts, words that He might speak in season to the weary and oppressed. 'The Lord God hath given Me,' He said, 'the tongue of the learned, that I should know how to speak a word in season to him that is weary; He wakeneth morning by morning, He wakeneth Mine ear to hear as the learned.' Isaiah 50:4." –*Christ's Object Lessons*, p. 139.

"Christ is the Captain of our salvation, and by His own sufferings and sacrifice He has given an example to all His followers that watchfulness and prayer, and persevering effort, were necessary on their part if they would rightly represent the love which dwelt in His bosom for the fallen race."

–*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 2, p. 664

"He often spent whole nights in prayer. While the cities were hushed in slumber, angels listened to the pleadings of the Redeemer. See the Saviour bowed in prayer, His soul wrung with anguish. He is not praying for Himself, but for those whom He came to save. In the mountains of Galilee and in the groves of Olivet the Beloved of God prayed for sinners. Then He came forth to minister to them, His tongue touched anew with living fire." –*Signs of the Times*, September 5, 1900.

Conclusion

Dear brothers and sisters, the Lord Jesus Christ gives us an invitation as we are just a few days away from the end of this year, 2024. Perhaps we find ourselves in difficult situations, carrying different problems, and distanced from the Divine Master. "Come ye yourselves apart into a desert place, and rest a while." Mark 6:31.

"If we would give heed to His word, we should be stronger and more useful. The disciples sought Jesus, and told Him all things; and He encouraged and instructed them. If today we would take time to go to Jesus and tell Him our needs, we should not be disappointed; He would be at our right hand to help us." –*The Desire of Ages*, p. 363.

"The Garden of Gethsemane was among the places thus frequented. It was to this place, when the city of Jerusalem was hushed in the silence of midnight, that Jesus often repaired for communion with His Father. When those to whom He had ministered all the day went every man to his house, Jesus, we read, 'went unto the Mount of Olives.' He would sometimes take His disciples with Him to this place of retirement, that they might join their prayers with His. In prayer Christ had power with God, and prevailed. Morning by morning, and

evening by evening, He received grace that He might impart to others. Then, His soul replenished with grace and fervor, He would set forth to minister to the souls of men." –*Signs of the Times*, July 15, 1908.

"Christ's lessons in regard to prayer should be carefully considered. There is a divine science in prayer, and His illustration brings to view principles that all need to understand. He shows what is the true spirit of prayer, He teaches the necessity of perseverance in presenting our requests to God, and assures us of His willingness to hear and answer prayer." –*Christ's Object Lessons*, p. 142.

Dear brothers and sisters everywhere, today, more than ever, we need to have a deep experience, an experience of prayer like that of Jesus. May this Week of Prayer bring us closer to our divine Model. And remember, the Saviour is coming soon! Get ready! Amen.

"Our Father which art in heaven,
Hallowed be thy name.
Thy kingdom come,
Thy will be done in earth,
as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread.
And forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil:
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power,
and the glory, for ever. Amen."
Matthew 6:9-13



THE LORD'S PRAYER

Elijah Zwane, Swaziland

“The disciples had been for a short time absent from their Lord, when on their return they found Him absorbed in communion with God. Seeming unconscious of their presence, He continued praying aloud. The Saviour’s face was irradiated with a celestial brightness. He seemed to be in the very presence of the Unseen, and there was a living power in His words as of one who spoke with God.” *—Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 102.

The Saviour understood three major things in the conflict with evil. He understood the seriousness of the work that He had come to do. He understood the shortness of the time that He had to finish that work. And He also understood the nature of the battle that Satan and all the powers of darkness were waging against Him to gain victory over the earth and its inhabitants. “For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities,

against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places.” Philippians 6:12. It was only through prayer that Christ could prevail.

“And it came to pass, that, as He was praying in a certain place, when He ceased, one of His disciples said unto Him, Lord, teach us to pray, as John also taught his disciples.” Luke 11:1. According to Luke’s account, when the disciples saw the success that attended the work of Jesus and the multitudes that followed Him wherever He went, teaching and healing the sick, they realized that He could perform all of these things because of the seasons of prayer that He treasured. After a long day’s work, He would often leave His disciples for some secluded place where He could pray alone and obtain strength for each day.

Why was it important to learn how to pray? Even John the Bap-

tist, Jesus’ forerunner, taught his disciples how to pray. Jesus also said, “Watch and pray, that ye enter not into temptation.” Matthew 26:41. But another reason is found in James 4:3: “Ye ask, and receive not, because ye ask amiss...” (meaning not quite right, inappropriately). You may have been praying and came to a point where you felt that God was not answering your prayers. Perhaps you asked many questions without receiving answers, coming to the point of despair. The truth is that there is no fault with God. We do not know how to pray and approach the throne of grace. God’s promise has always been sure and true, “Ask, and it shall be given you.” Matthew 7:7.

In answer to the request of His disciples, Jesus taught them a prayer that was “so simple that they may be adopted by the little child, yet so comprehensive that their significance can never be fully grasped by the great-

est minds. We are taught to come to God with our tribute of thanksgiving, to make known our wants, to confess our sins, and to claim His mercy in accordance with His promise.” –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 103.

“Our Father which art in heaven”

“Jesus teaches us to call His Father our Father. He is not ashamed to call us brethren. Hebrews 2:11. So ready, so eager, is the Saviour’s heart to welcome us as members of the family of God, that in the very first words we are to use in approaching God He places the assurance of our divine relationship, ‘Our Father.’” –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 103.

After His resurrection, when Jesus appeared to Mary, He forbade her to touch Him because He had not ascended to His Father. He said to her, “... go to My brethren, and say unto them, I ascend unto My Father, and your Father;...” John 20:17.

“By His life and His death, Christ has achieved even more than recovery from the ruin wrought through sin. It was Satan’s purpose to bring about an eternal separation between God and man; but in Christ we become more closely united to God than if we had never fallen. In taking our nature, the Saviour has bound Himself to humanity by a tie that is never to be broken. Through the eternal ages He is linked with us.... God has adopted human nature in the person of His Son, and has carried the same into the highest heaven.” –*Reflecting Christ*, p. 45.

That is why the apostle Paul said, “Let us therefore come boldly unto the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy, and find grace to help in time of need.” Hebrews 4:16.

“In calling God our Father, we recognize all His children as our brethren. We are all a part of the great web of humanity, all members of one family. In our petitions we are to include our neighbors as well as ourselves. No one prays aright who seeks a blessing for himself alone.” –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 105.

We should not have the spirit of Cain, who asserted that he was not his brother’s keeper. Nor are we to be indifferent to others, like the priest and Levite, as Jesus taught in the parable of the Good Samaritan. Instead, we are to be like Joseph. He left his father’s house to look for his brothers at the risk of being injured or even losing life. We are indebted to our fellow beings, whether in the family circle, the neighborhood, the work place, or at school. Many are lost and need someone to show them the way to the cross. Some could be strangers in a foreign land with no friends or hope. We are to leave the comfort of our homes, look for our brothers, and give them the Father’s sweet promises. Furthermore, in addition to calling God our Father, we will be obedient to His commandments and submit our will to His will. It will be a great joy and delight to do any act, however humble, that will tend to the glory of God and bless our kindred.

“Hallowed be Thy name”

“To hallow the name of the Lord requires that the words in which we speak of the Supreme Being be uttered with reverence. ‘Holy and reverend is His name.’ Psalm 111:9. We are never in any manner to treat lightly the titles or appellations of the Deity. In prayer we enter the audience chamber of the Most High; and we should come before Him with

holy awe. The angels veil their faces in His presence. The cherubim and the bright and holy seraphim approach His throne with solemn reverence. How much more should we, finite, sinful beings, come in a reverent manner before the Lord, our Maker!” –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 106.

Sometimes we show that we do not understand how reverent God’s name is by calling fellow human beings “Reverend.” The servant of God wrote, “According to the teaching of the Scriptures, it dishonors God to address ministers as ‘Reverend.’ No mortal has any right to attach this to his own name or to the name of any other human being. It belongs only to God, to distinguish Him from every other being. Those who lay claim to this title take to themselves God’s holy honor. They have no right to the stolen word, whatever their position may be. ‘Holy and reverend is His name.’” –*Evangelism*, p. 133.

“Our petitions must not take the form of a command, but of intercession for Him to do the things we desire of Him.”

–*Counsels on Health*, p. 379.

When presenting our petitions to God, we need to be very careful of our tone. “I saw that God’s holy name should be used with reverence and awe. The words God Almighty are coupled together and used by some in prayer in a careless, thoughtless manner, which is displeasing to Him. Such have no realizing sense of God or the truth, or they would not speak so irreverently of the great and dreadful God, who is soon to judge them in the last day. Said the angel, ‘Cou-

ple them not together; for fearful is His name.' Those who realize the greatness and majesty of God will take His name on their lips with holy awe. He dwelleth in light unapproachable; no man can see Him and live." –*Counsels to the Church*, p. 252.

"Do we realize that we must hallow that name in our families, and that if we allow our children to manifest the attributes of Satan, that name is not hallowed in our households? If we want the holy angels to take charge of our little ones, we must bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord, and teach them to hallow the name of God." –*Review and Herald*, July 16, 1895.

Parents, as we study these Readings for the Week of Prayer, where are your children? Fathers, how are you leading your households? Are we representing God's character and attributes in our lives?

"Thy kingdom come"

What is the kingdom of God? "For the kingdom of God is not meat and drink; but righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost." Romans 14:17.

"The disciples of Christ were looking for the immediate coming of the kingdom of His glory, but in giving them this prayer Jesus taught that the kingdom was not then to be established. They were to pray for its coming as an event yet in the future. But this petition was also an assurance to them. While they were not to behold the coming of the kingdom in their day, the fact that Jesus bade them pray for it is evidence that in God's own time it will surely come." –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 107.

How does one prepare for the coming kingdom? We cannot pray for the kingdom to come if we are not ready. Our lives must

correspond with our faith. We are in the world but not of the world as Christ's kingdom is also not of this world.

We are looking for the fulfillment of this prayer after the second coming of Christ. "And the kingdom and dominion, and the greatness of the kingdom under the whole heaven, shall be given to the people of the saints of the most High, whose kingdom is an everlasting kingdom, and all dominions shall serve and obey Him." Daniel 7:27. Now we are in the kingdom of grace, but we look forward to that kingdom of glory, the climax and realization of the hope of salvation.

"Thy will be done"

What is God's will? "I delight to do Thy will, O my God: yea, Thy law is within my heart." Psalm 40:8.

"The will of God is expressed in the precepts of His holy law, and the principles of this law are the principles of heaven. The angels of heaven attain unto no higher knowledge than to know the will of God, and to do His will is the highest service that can engage their powers." –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 109.

The petition, "Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven," is a prayer that the reign of evil on this earth will be ended, that sin will be forever destroyed, and that the kingdom of righteousness will be established. Then, in earth as in heaven, will be fulfilled "all the good pleasure of His goodness." 2 Thessalonians 1:11.

Now, to a great extent, Satan has successfully blinded the minds of so-called Christians to the law of God, which reflects the foundation of His government. We can never be in harmony and at peace with God while transgressing His law. "Great peace have they which love Thy law: and nothing shall offend them."

Psalm 119:165. The whole of Christendom professes to love Christ while trampling upon His law.

"But the day is coming in which the battle will have been fought, the victory won. The will of God is to be done on earth, as it is done in heaven. Then the nations will own no other law than the law of heaven. All will be a happy, united family, clothed with the garments of praise and thanksgiving—the robe of Christ's righteousness." –*Counsels for the Church*, p. 341.

"Give us this day our daily bread"

Just like the ten commandments, which are divided into two parts—the first showing man's love for God and the second revealing one's love for his fellowmen—so it is with the Lord's Prayer. The first part shows a person's reverence for God, glorifying Him and doing that which is His will. In the second part of the Lord's Prayer, after one has done the Father's will, he can present to Him his petitions for his own needs and those of others. "But my God shall supply all your need according to His riches in glory by Christ Jesus." Philippians 4:19.

**"So ready, so eager,
is the Saviour's heart
to welcome us as
members of the family
of God, that in the very
first words we are to
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God He places the
assurance of our divine
relationship, 'Our
Father.'"**

–*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 103.

“The prayer for daily bread includes not only food to sustain the body, but that spiritual bread which will nourish the soul unto life everlasting. Jesus bids us, ‘Labor not for the meat which perisheth, but for that meat which endureth unto everlasting life.’ John 6:27. He says, ‘I am the living bread which came down from heaven: if any man eat of this bread, he shall live forever.’ Verse 51. Our Saviour is the bread of life, and it is by beholding His love, by receiving it into the soul, that we feed upon the bread which came down from heaven....”

“In teaching us to ask every day for what we need—both temporal and spiritual blessings—God has a purpose to accomplish for our good. He would have us realize our dependence upon His constant care, for He is seeking to draw us into communion with Himself.” *—Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, pp. 112, 113.

One important “lesson to be taught ... is the lesson of dependence upon God.... As a flower of the field has its root in the soil; as it must receive air, dew, showers, and sunshine, so must we receive from God that which ministers to the life of the soul.” *—Our Father Cares*, p. 20.

“There is only one source from which we can draw nourishment and strength and intelligence, and that is from God. He wants every man to humble his soul before Him; for we are all dependent upon God. He wants us to lean heavily upon Him.”

—Manuscript 57, 1906.

We are dependent on our Father in heaven for our physical and spiritual nourishment. But why do we have to pray that it be given to us daily instead of asking Him just one time to give us all that we need? Simply because God’s mercies are new every morning. Another reason is presented in the following lines of the Spirit of prophecy: “But you are as a child who is not yet placed in control of his inheritance. God does not entrust to you your precious possession, lest Satan by his wily arts should beguile you, as he did the first pair in Eden. Christ holds it for you, safe beyond the spoiler’s reach. Like the child, you shall receive day by day what is required for the day’s need. Every day you are to pray, ‘Give us this day our daily bread.’” *—Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 110.

“Forgive us our debts, as we also forgive”

In this prayer we are literally saying, God will deal with us as we deal with our fellowmen. “We should not think that unless those who have injured us confess the wrong we are justified in withholding from them our forgiveness. It is their part, no doubt, to humble their hearts by repentance and confession; but we are to have a spirit of compassion toward those who have trespassed against us, whether or not they confess their faults. However sorely they may have wounded us, we are not to cherish our grievances and sympathize with ourselves over our injuries; but as we hope to be pardoned for our offenses against God, we are to pardon all who have done evil to us.” *—Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, pp. 113, 114.

Forgiveness is one of God’s attributes, as He said to Moses. “The Lord God, merciful,... forgiving

transgression and sin,...” Exodus 34:6, 7. As the soldiers were driving nails into His hands, Jesus said, “Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do.” Luke 23:34. A few years later, when Stephen was stoned, “he kneeled down, and cried with a loud voice, Lord, lay not this sin to their charge....” Acts 7:60. Also, Saul the persecutor, after he became Paul in his conversion, wrote to Timothy, “At my first answer no man stood with me, but all men forsook me: I pray God that it may not be laid to their charge.” 2 Timothy 4:16. The secret to forgiveness is understanding that, when we do not forgive, we are allowing the rubbish of grudges and hatred to block our minds, the channels through which we receive God’s forgiveness. Unforgiveness may even lead to illness which no physician but Christ can cure.

I remember a story about a sister who was very ill, and everything had been tried to help her. Ministers were asked to come for an anointing service. After special seasons of prayers were offered, one minister asked the sister to recite the Lord’s prayer with him. The sister gladly did that with her ailing voice. But when it came to this part, “And forgive us our sins; for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us” (Luke 11:4), the sister was silent. The pastor repeated that sentence, but the sister was silent. He stopped praying and asked her why she was not repeating the phrase after him. She said that someone had hurt her so much that she would never forgive him. Sadly, the sister died without forgiving.

It is true that “woe” is pronounced on those who offend others, but as God’s children we need to forgive. We need to petition God for this attribute, for the carnal heart does not possess it. Today because of an unforgiving spirit, there are broken relationships in families

and, sadly, even in the house of faith among brethren.

"Everyone who has to deal with others should make their case his own; for just as we deal with others will God deal with us. We are treating Christ as we treat His children; for He is represented in the person of His saints." –*Signs of the Times*, February 3, 1890.

"Lead us not into temptation"

What is temptation? Temptation is enticement to sin, and according to the Bible it does not come from God. Temptation is like having birds hovering over our heads, and it is not a sin for them to do so. But allowing them to build nests on our heads would make such temptations sins. Thus, being tempted is not a sin, but yielding to it is. For almost six thousand years, Satan's studied effort has been to deceive and destroy humanity through the skill and subtlety that he developed over the millennia. How does he do this?

"Satan seeks to bring us into temptation, that the evil of our characters may be revealed before men and angels, that he may claim us as his own. In the symbolic prophecy of Zechariah, Satan is seen standing at the right hand of the Angel of the Lord, accusing Joshua, the high priest, who is clothed in filthy garments, and resisting the work that the Angel desires to do for him. This represents the attitude of Satan toward every soul whom Christ is seeking to draw unto Himself. The enemy leads us into sin, and then he accuses us before the heavenly universe as unworthy of the love of God." –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, pp. 116, 117.

However, we need not despair, because, for every temptation borne and resisted through divine aid, there is a blessing in gaining the experience and advancing in

character building. But if we fall into temptation, we sin against God; and then, in the balances of heaven, we shall be found wanting. Christ sees our every temptation; He has made every provision so that we can bear it. He promised that we will not be tempted beyond what we can bear. In offering the prayer that Christ has given, we surrender ourselves to God's guidance, asking Him to lead us in safe paths. We cannot offer this prayer in sincerity and then walk in some way of our own choosing. A sincere Christian will never make plans that God cannot approve. At the same time, he will never venture on forbidden ground and expose himself to Satan's influence. Therefore, in this prayer, we ask God to save us from ourselves and to make the temptations lessons that help to prepare us for eternal life.

"Thine is the kingdom, the power, and the glory"

Christ came to earth at the time when the yoke of the oppressor was heavy upon God's people. The disciples and the people had a very limited understanding of the mission that Christ had come to accomplish. They thought that He had come to free the Jews from the Romans and to establish His kingdom on earth. But Christ told Pilate before His crucifixion, "My kingdom is not of this world:..." John 18:36. Therefore when Christ gave the Lord's Prayer to His disciples, He made sure to remove misconceptions from their minds and point them to His future kingdom. Also, He assured them that God was in full control, even though they would be oppressed for a time, the powers of evil would seem to prevail among God's people, Jerusalem would be destroyed, and God's people would be scattered in foreign lands. He

will make all things right in His own time. The powers of evil can operate only as much as God permits, because all power and glory belong to Him.

"Yet Christ's followers were not to fear that their hope was lost or that God had forsaken the earth. The power and the glory belong unto Him whose great purposes would still move on unthwarted toward their consummation. In the prayer that breathes their daily wants, the disciples of Christ were directed to look above all the power and dominion of evil, unto the Lord their God, whose kingdom ruleth over all and who is their Father and everlasting Friend." –*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 120.

May God help us to draw closer to Him in prayer than ever before, for unto Him belong all power and glory forever and ever. Amen!

**"But you are as a
child who is not yet
placed in control of his
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lest Satan by his wily
arts should beguile
you, as he did the first
pair in Eden. Christ
holds it for you, safe
beyond the spoiler's
reach. Like the child,
you shall receive day
by day what is required
for the day's need.
Every day you are to
pray, 'Give us this day
our daily bread.'"**

–*Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 110.

PRAY FOR YOUR ENEMIES

Pablo Hunger, Argentina / U.S.A.



WOP 2024 – "Praying Always"

“...Father, forgive them: for they know not what they do...” (Luke 23:34) were the words that Jesus spoke in His most painful moments as His hands were pierced by huge nails on the cross. What a great example to follow from our Teacher!

Jesus had done nothing to be put to death by crucifixion, but He asked for forgiveness instead of judgment for those who crucified Him. Sadly, most of the time, we are guilty of hurting someone or causing strife between people or enmity through our words, actions, and even antichristian looks.

Every day, we face situations and actions of our peers that can lead us to consider other people our enemies. The truth is that there are differences within the closest circle of the family, at work, between neighbors, and even in the church. But we must not allow challenges, differences, or attitudes of others to make us change our Christian attitude of love for our fellowmen.

The enemy of God wants to destroy the family and society. He does everything possible to create problems among neighbors and cause divisions in the church. However, by His own life, Jesus taught what it means to live by clinging to God and His love.

How often do we create distances because someone did not greet us, responded to something we said in an unpleasant manner, or said something to us that we did not like? And then, without asking any questions, we imagine that the person has a problem with us. In many cases, our imaginations need to change. How many times have you felt terrible about a situation that you experienced at work or something that did not work out well in your own life, and then you were unintentionally affected by the experience of that day? After that, we may neglect our own family members and fellow human beings who had

nothing to do with what we experienced.

Can a real Christian act like an enemy? In Matthew 5:44, Jesus taught: “But I say unto you, Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you.”

We see from Jesus' statement that the center of the Christian life is love, which is the opposite of enmity. The works of the flesh that are listed in Galatians 5:20 are sinful and opposed to God, including “hatred, variance, emulations, wrath, strife, seditions.” Do not let such sins take root in your heart and mind!

What is enmity? Enmity is a state of hostility or deep animosity between individuals, groups, or communities. It is characterized by intense negative feelings, such as resentment, dislike, or contempt; and it is often linked to previous conflicts, differences, or negative experiences.

Let us examine why enmities arise and what can be done to avoid falling into such traps.

Differences of opinion

Feuds often arise between individuals and families because of significant disagreements in regard to views, values, or beliefs, leading to conflicts between individuals who see the world in different ways. Even in marriage, there are differences of opinion that, if left unresolved, can lead to serious difficulties. Different points of view and different opinions can broaden our limited vision if we are open to listening to others and allowing them to express themselves, particularly if they are not contrary to God's will. Examining such differences carefully is important, for they can otherwise lead to even greater divisions. The actions of the Holy Spirit unite believers in the truth. Try to put yourself in your neighbor's shoes to understand why he thinks differently from you. Seek unity of opinion. And if there are differences, seek to respect those who have different points of view and ask God to help you to understand your neighbor.

Misunderstandings

Lack of clear communication or misunderstandings can lead to misconceptions and unnecessary conflicts, fueling feuds that could have been avoided with better communication. Communication difficulties can also be present in families. Many conflicts would be avoided if we would only put some effort into exercising loving communication. Seek to understand your neighbor without drawing conclusions which are all too often incorrect. If something seems wrong to you, follow Jesus' teaching

in Matthew 5:23, 24: "Therefore if thou bring thy gift to the altar, and there rememberest that thy brother hath ought against thee: Leave there thy gift before the altar, and go thy way; first be reconciled to thy brother, and then come and offer thy gift." The wise counsel of God's word is to seek reconciliation when we see that something has caused a difficulty between us and someone else.

Emotional wounds

Past experiences of betrayal, disappointment, or emotional pain can leave behind deep scars, creating resentments that fuel feuds over time. Do not let negative experiences scar your life. When the Lord forgives, He will "cast all their sins into the depths of the sea," according to Micah 7:19, implying that He forgets them. Ask the Lord to remove negative feelings from your heart, because they do not come from heaven and do not contribute to your being able to love those around you and have peace with God.

Interpersonal competition

In competitive environments, whether at work or in social situations, rivalry for success or attention can lead to hostilities between individuals who are perceived as competitors. This is very common among fellow employees when a promotion to a better position or greater responsibility and salary arises. But such competition is not Christlike and is the result of selfishness. Our mission is to serve others with all our hearts, as the apostle Paul taught in Colossians 3:23, 24. "And whatsoever ye do, do it heartily, as to the Lord, and not unto men; Knowing that of the Lord ye shall receive the reward

of the inheritance: for ye serve the Lord Christ."

Lack of empathy

The inability to understand and empathize with others will surely lead to hostile attitudes and the formation of hostilities because the human connection that is necessary to build healthy relationships has been lost. The principle of heaven is to serve others, not oneself. Practice kindness!

Cultural differences

Cultural diversity can lead to misunderstanding, tension, and hostility if it is not addressed with respect and understanding. Remember, there is only one culture—the heavenly one. Our citizenship is not on this earth but in heaven, according to Philippians 3:20, where there is one God and Father of all. While we are in this world, let us seek to understand our fellow human beings even when they have customs that are different from our own, as long as they are not offensive to God.

Competition for resources

Fighting over limited resources, such as power, recognition, or even material goods can fuel great unhappiness between people or groups that compete for such things. Christian values are the opposite of such a struggle for power, authority, or resources. "Then Jesus called them unto Him, and said, Ye know that the princes of the Gentiles exercise dominion over them, and they that are great exercise authority upon them. But it shall not be so among you: but whosoever will be great among you, let him be your minister; And whosoever will be chief among you, let him be

your servant: Even as the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give His life a ransom for many.” Matthew 20:25-28.

Consider the following story of Alexander and Carl, two brothers whose lives took very different paths following a dispute over an inheritance. The problem arose when their grandfather divided his property unequally, leading to deep resentments. Over the years, the rivalry intensified, with misunderstandings and misinterpreted actions, leading to legal actions that pitted cousins, uncles, and grandparents against each other for generations.

The same thing happened in Abraham’s family. There was a dispute between Sarah and Hagar, but it did not end with them. Their descendants in the Middle East have warred for centuries to this very day, with great loss of life because of the family conflict, even though Israel and the Palestinians came from the same father.

Differences of opinion are present in every family, work environment, social group, and church. Nevertheless, a faithful Christian will not let such differences cause division or enmity. We must ask the Lord to give us the Spirit of Christ to bring about divine transformation and live in that unity that heaven desires for its children.

Can a Christian hold onto an offense? What did the Master say about this? “For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.” Matthew 6:14, 15.

Jesus added those words after ending the Lord’s Prayer. “He who is unforgiving cuts off the very channel through which alone he can receive mercy from God. We should not think that unless those who have injured us confess the

wrong, we are justified in withholding from them our forgiveness. It is their part, no doubt, to humble their hearts by repentance and confession; but we are to have a spirit of compassion toward those who have trespassed against us, whether or not they confess their faults. However sorely they may have wounded us, we are not to cherish our grievances and sympathize with ourselves over our injuries; but as we hope to be pardoned for our offenses against God, we are to pardon all who have done evil to us.” *—Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 113.

Do not hold any offense in your heart. Do not allow the seed of evil to produce resentment, anger, or hatred in your heart, but forgive those who act improperly toward you.

“Love your enemies, bless them that curse you.” Matthew 5:44. “We are to love our enemies with the same love that Christ manifested toward His enemies by giving His life to save them. Many may say, ‘This is a hard commandment; for I want to keep just as far as I can from my enemies.’ But acting in accordance with your own inclination would not be carrying out the principles that our Saviour has given. ‘Do good,’ He says, ‘to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you; that ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven: for He maketh His sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.’ This scripture illustrates one phase of Christian perfection. While we were yet enemies of God, Christ gave His life for us. We are to follow His example.” *—Medical Ministry*, p. 335.

Praying for those who reject and persecute you is an indicator of true Christian transforma-

tion. Such prayer fosters compassion and the desire to help those who are blinded by the enemy. You will be given strength to forgive, not just once, but as often as necessary. You are actually seeking for lasting reconciliation and to avoid experiences that can lead to suffering for generations, for which you are actually responsible. Such prayers signs of deep spiritual growth, for God is taking control of your actions, words, thoughts, and feelings.

Ask God to give you the experience that the apostle Paul described in Romans 12:20, 21. “Therefore if thine enemy hunger, feed him: if he thirst, give him drink: for in so doing thou shalt heap coals of fire on his head. Be not overcome of evil, but overcome evil with good.”

Let us all follow the counsel of Hebrews 12:14: “Follow peace with all men, and holiness, without which no man shall see the Lord.”

God help us to be “ambassadors of reconciliation” (2 Corinthians 5:20) in our homes, with our wives, with our children, in our work environment, with our neighbors, and with our fellow believers in the faith. The result will be a proper representation of the kingdom of heaven, the heavenly Canaan, the home where we will all live together for eternity. Amen!

“But I say unto you,
Love your enemies,
bless them that curse
you, do good to them
that hate you, and
pray for them which
despitefully use you,
and persecute you.”

Matthew 5:44

HEALING PRAYER

Idel Suarez, Jr., U.S.A.

“Is any sick among you? let him call for the elders of the church; and let them pray over him, anointing him with oil in the name of the Lord: And the prayer of faith shall save the sick, and the Lord shall raise him up; and if he have committed sins, they shall be forgiven him, and pray one for another, that ye may be healed. The effectual fervent prayer of a righteous man availeth much.” James 5:14-16.

When I was about twelve years old, we lived in Costa Rica. I remember that my little brother came down sick, and my mother took a taxi to go and find an ordained church elder. When we arrived at his home, he invited us in. My mom told him the problem. My brother had a terrible fever. He was suffering from an intestinal blockage caused by something that he had eaten. The elder immediately took some oil and started to massage my brother's abdomen in a clockwise motion (from right to left) along with his lymph nodes,

applying manual pressure. Then he prayed for my brother, and immediately the fever went away. He was completely restored. We were all so happy!

The opening text says to call for the elders of the church, but sometimes one has to travel to find them. The above ordained elder was Brother Nautilio Bolaños, and he had experience with healing. He not only anointed my sick brother with oil and massaged his abdomen and lymph nodes, but he also offered a prayer of faith, which brought healing.

After being a Pastor, I too have used the same massage techniques with olive oil and prayed for the sick after they confessed their sins to God. I urged them to turn to Jesus with all their hearts. I have found the promise of Jesus to be true: “They shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover.” Mark 16:18.

God is the true Healer. He was presented in the Old Testament as Jehovah-Rophi—the Lord your Healer. Exodus 15:26.

We need to differentiate the solemn act of prayer in anointing the sick with oil, which is performed by elders and ministers, from the common healing prayer for the sick, which any person may offer. The former is reserved for very sick members, while the latter is for both members and nonmembers. Especially the latter is an instrument of evangelistic medical missionary work.

But there are conditions for both the anointing of the sick and the common prayer for healing. Let us examine them in the light of the Bible and the testimonies.

Scientific evidence of healing prayer

A CNN poll found that 77 percent of Americans believe that praying for someone who is sick has a beneficial effect. ¹Numerous double-blind controlled research studies funded by the National In-

¹ Marilyn Schlitz, “Meditation, Prayer and Spiritual Healing: The Evidence,” *Permanente Journal* (Summer 2005), 9(6), pp. 63-66.

stitutes of Health in the USA have shown that intercessory prayer has positive health outcomes and provides healing.² Even when praying for treatments and medications they can be more successful (just as we pray for food I Timothy 4:5).³ Psychiatrists have even found that prayer significantly improves mental health and contributes to healing in trauma and psychosis.⁴ In short, healing prayer is effective.

Only for those who accept the three angels' messages

Prayer for the sick in which the sacred anointing oil is applied is reserved for those who uphold the three angels' messages. Only those who are members of the remnant church or who have decided to join it are to call upon the elders and ministers to anoint them when they are sick. It is not for those who deliberately transgress God's Ten Commandments.

"You inquire if we should pray for none that are sick except those in the third angel's message, or pray for all that shall make application, etcetera. James 5 is our rule to follow. 'Is any sick among you? let him call,' etcetera. It is those that are among us. God had shown me those who keep God's commandments are to have nothing to do [in anointing and special prayer] for the sick of those who are daily trampling them underfoot, unless it is in some special case where souls are convicted of the truth and are decided to move out upon it. The partition wall between commandment keepers and those who trample them underfoot should be kept."⁵

² Ibid.

³ Ibid.

⁴ Tanya Marie Luhmann, "Making God Real, Making God Good: Some mechanisms through which prayer may contribute to healing," *Transcultural Psychology*, 2013, 0(0), pp. 1-19.

⁵ Ellen G. White, Letter 4, 1857; *Pastoral Ministry*, p. 233.

This does not mean that we cannot pray for the sick in hospitals who are not members of God's church. The above restriction applies exclusively to the act of anointing the sick as performed by prophets, elders, and pastors.

Confession

James wrote that confession is a dynamic component of healing prayer. "Confess your faults one to another,..." James 5:16. Before Jesus healed a quadriplegic man who was brought to Him at Simon Peter's home, the Saviour first forgave the man's sins. Only then was the sufferer ready for physical healing. Thus, spiritual healing precedes physical healing.

The psalmist also taught that one should pray to God for healing. He understood that forgiveness of sin must precede the healing of disease. "Bless the Lord, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless His holy name. Bless the Lord, O my soul, and forget not all His benefits: who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases; who redeemeth thy life from destruction; who crowneth thee with lovingkindness and tender mercy." Psalm 103:1-4.

"To those who desire prayer for their restoration to health, it should be made plain that the violation of God's law, either natural or spiritual, is sin, and that for them to receive His blessing, sin must be confessed and forsaken...."⁶

⁶ Ellen G. White, "Prayer for the Sick," *The Ministry of Healing*, p. 228.

"If any who are seeking health have been guilty of evil speaking, if they have sowed discord in the home, the neighborhood, or the church, and have stirred up alienation and dissension, if by any wrong practice they have led others into sin, these things should be confessed before God and before those who have been offended. 'If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.' 1 John 1:9."⁷

Errors need to be corrected. Peace must be restored between the sick and God and between the sick and others. Even the testimonies say that the tithe must be restored just as interpersonal relationships are restored.

"We should first find out if the sick one has been withholding tithes or has created difficulties in the church."⁸

Faith

After the one who is sick has confessed his sins to God, we need to pray with faith for healing, believing that God will hear our petitions. "Without faith, it is impossible to please" God. Hebrews 11:6. Jesus said, "... All things are possible to him that believeth." Mark 9:23.

"When wrongs have been righted, we may present the needs of the sick to the Lord in calm faith, as His Spirit may indicate. He knows each individual by name, and cares for each as if there were not another upon the earth for whom He gave His beloved Son. Because God's love is so great and so unfailing, the sick should be encouraged to trust in Him and be cheerful."⁹

"The prayer of faith in the sickroom, short and right to the

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Ellen G. White, "Prayer for the Sick," *Healthful Living*, p. 237.

⁹ Ellen G. White, "Prayer for the Sick," *The Ministry of Healing*, p. 229.

point, prepares the way for the grace of God to speak to the soul. Even unbelievers feel this—to them—strange and new influence, and realize that God can and will hear their prayers.”¹⁰

According to His will

No prayer should ever be offered to God without making it subject to the will of God. He knows the future, which we cannot see. He knows if it will be better not to heal the “thorn in the flesh.” 2 Corinthians 12:7.

“Many would not
endure the time
of trial, and will
therefore be laid
away.”¹¹

Paul pleaded with God three times to heal him, but God replied “No.” He extended grace to Paul to bear his infirmity or “thorn in the flesh.” This thorn in the flesh would help to keep Paul humble and meek. Hence, we want to pray for the healing of the sick, but subject to “His will.”

“He [God] reads every secret of the soul. He knows whether those for whom prayer is offered would or would not be able to endure the trials that would come upon them should they live. He knows whether their lives would be a blessing or a curse to themselves and to the world. This is one reason why, while presenting our petitions with earnestness, we should say, ‘Nevertheless not my will, but Thine, be done.’ Luke 22:42. Jesus added these words of submission to the wisdom and will of God when in the Garden of Gethsemane He pleaded, ‘O My Father, if it be

possible, let this cup pass from Me.’ Matthew 26:39. And if they were appropriate for Him, the Son of God, how much more are they becoming on the lips of finite, erring mortals!”¹²

“Therefore, our prayers should include this thought: ‘Lord, thou knowest every secret of the soul. Thou art acquainted with these persons. Jesus, their Advocate, gave His life for them. His love for them is greater than ours can be. If, therefore, it is for Thy glory and the good of the afflicted ones, we ask, in the name of Jesus, that they may be restored to health. If it be not Thy will that they may be restored, we ask that Thy grace may comfort and Thy presence sustain them in their sufferings.’”¹³

In the name of Jesus

Jesus taught us to pray in His name. In His name, the apostles were able to heal the sick. In His name, we can pray for the healing of the sick. Jesus promised to answer the petitions of those who keep His commandments (1 John 3:22) and pray in His name. He repeated this many times. “If ye shall ask any thing in My name, I will do it.” “... That whatsoever ye shall ask of the Father in My name, He may give it you.” “Whatsoever ye shall ask the Father in My name, He will give it you.” John 14:14; 15:16; 16:23.

“We ask, in the
name of Jesus,
that they may be
restored to health.”

Pastor Larry Watts was once visiting the believers in India, and a childless couple came to him for help. They had sought help

from physicians to no avail. The wife appeared to be barren. Then Pastor Watts spoke to them. He prayed for them in the name of Jesus and according to His will. The next time he visited that country, the woman told him that she got pregnant immediately thereafter and had a beautiful baby. Healing prayer works.

With olive oil

Olive oil is the best type of oil. It was the sacred oil in the sanctuary. It was used to anoint the prophet, the priest, and the king. Jesus was all three. Today, ordained elders and ministers or pastors officiate in the anointing of the sick with oil and offering prayers for the healing of the sick. However, we have evidence that Sister White also anointed the sick with holy oil. Why? Because she was a prophet. Prophets may also anoint the sick.

“The question has been asked by some, ‘Has Sister White healed the sick?’ I answer, ‘No, no; Sister White has often been called to pray for the sick, and to anoint them with oil in the name of the Lord Jesus, and with them she has claimed the fulfillment of the promise, ‘The prayer of faith shall save the sick.’”¹⁴

The use of natural remedies

When King Hezekiah was sick with a terminal illness, he called upon God to extend His mercy to him. God answered his prayer and advised that natural remedies be used for his restoration. It would have been a denial of faith if the king would not have used the simple remedies to aid in his recovery.

“... While they place themselves before God to be prayed for that they may be healed,

¹⁰ Ellen G. White, *Manuscript Releases*, vol. 21, p. 43.

¹¹ Ellen G. White, “Pray for the Sick,” *Healthful Living*, p. 238.

¹² Ellen G. White, “Prayer for the Sick,” *The Ministry of Healing*, p. 230.

¹³ *Ibid.*, p. 229.

¹⁴ Ellen G. White, *Selected Messages*, vol. 3, p. 295.

they are not to neglect methods of restoration to health that are in accordance with nature's laws. If, in praying for healing, they refuse to use the simple remedies provided by God to alleviate pain and to aid nature in her work, lest it be a denial of faith, they are taking an unwise position. It is not a denial of faith, it is in strict harmony with the plans of God.... One word from God, one touch of the divine finger, would have cured Hezekiah instantly, but special directions were given to take a fig and lay it on the affected part, and Hezekiah was raised to life. In everything we need to move along the line of God's providence. The human agent should have faith, and should cooperate with divine power, using every facility, taking advantage of everything that to his intelligence is beneficial, and working in harmony with natural laws; in doing this he neither denies nor hinders faith.”¹⁵

“On one occasion Christ anointed the eyes of a blind man with clay and bade him, ‘Go, wash in the pool of Siloam.... He went his way therefore, and washed, and came seeing.’ John 9:7. The cure could be wrought only by the power of the Great Healer, yet Christ made use of the simple agencies of nature. While He did not give countenance to drug medication, He sanctioned the use of simple and natural remedies.”¹⁶

Natural remedies generally take longer to act than do drugs. Natural remedies do not damage the body or the brain as do drugs. Natural remedies do cure, rather than just treat the symptoms like drugs. Simple, natural remedies include prayer, water, sunshine, fresh air, a plant-based diet, exercise, faith, medicinal herbs, and the use of clay.

¹⁵ Ellen G. White, “Prayer for the Sick,” *Healthful Living*, pp. 240, 241.

¹⁶ Ellen G. White, “Prayer for the Sick,” *The Ministry of Healing*, p. 233.

Conclusion

Let us remember that God has the final word on the restoration of one's health and the remission of disease. As a nurse once told me: “It is not the doctor, the nurse, the patient, the family, or the minister who determines the outcome, but God.” We trust the loving hands that were nailed to Calvary's cross to decide the outcome.

There is a fascinating story told about the Mayo brothers, Will and Charlie, who opened the Mayo Clinic in Rochester, Minnesota, along with their father William. They were very successful as physicians in helping the sick. People would come to their clinic from around the world to be treated by them. Dr. Will Mayo said the following: “I have seen patients that were dead by all standards. We knew they could not live. But I have seen a minister come to the bedside and do something for him that I could not do, although I have done everything in my professional power. But something touched some immortal spark in him and in defiance of medical knowl-

edge and materialistic common sense, that patient LIVED!”¹⁷

As we close this year 2024, let us recall the commission of Christ to “heal the sick.” Let us pray for the sick according to His will and be prepared to see miracles right before our eyes.

“The commission Christ gave to the disciples He gives to all connected with Him.... You who are the elect and chosen ones are to receive the divine commission to yoke up with Christ.... The highest honor that can be conferred upon human beings, be they young or old, rich or poor, is to be permitted to lift up the oppressed, comfort the feeble-minded, and support the weak. The world is full of suffering; go, heal the sick, pray for the hopeless, preach the gospel to the poor.”¹⁸

Through healing prayer, may the Lord use you as an evangelistic medical missionary. May you become an agent of hope, a channel of light, and a messenger of health. Amen!

¹⁷ Paul Lee Tan, *Encyclopedia of 7700 Illustrations* (Rockville, MD: Assurance Publishers, 1979), p. 1046.

¹⁸ Ellen G. White, *The Youth's Instructor*, November 2, 1899.



“He will wipe every
tear from their eyes,
and there will be
no more death or
sorrow or crying or
pain. All these things
are gone forever.”

Revelation 21:4

PRAISING CONTINUALLY

Danilo Monterroso, Guatemala

We thank God that we are near the end of another year. We lift our prayers of thanksgiving to the throne of grace for life and mercy; for good things and bad; for trials and afflictions that have come to us as lessons; for friends and family who are away from us and whom we disappointed or betrayed; as well as for the gift of time to seek them out, reconcile with them, and ask for forgiveness; and for the loved ones whom we lost on the path of life but who fell asleep in the blessed hope. How many dreams and desires did we have? Some were achieved, and others turned into nightmares. But in all of this we can say, as did the apostle Paul in 1 Thessalonians 5:18: "In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you." God wants us to give thanks for everything. Let us be grateful, especially for the salvation that is granted to all in Christ Jesus our Saviour.

Prayer during crisis

Today, we hear of strange and frightening events that are happening around the world in fulfillment of prophecy. Many prophets of past ages would rejoice if they were alive today to see what we are seeing! They recorded coming events under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, and those things are being fulfilled exactly as they were written. "We are now standing on the threshold of great and solemn events. A crisis is before us, such as the world has never witnessed." *—Thoughts from the Mount of Blessing*, p. 120.

Today thousands of people in different parts of the world have experienced and continue to experience desperate situations that affect communities at the social, economic, and political levels. Furthermore, the increase in violence and evil is a concern shared by many political, religious, and social leaders. These

situations include armed conflicts, humanitarian crises, and economic and social inequalities, among other problems. Through the echo of history comes the intercessory prayer that Jesus offered to His Father on behalf of His followers in John 17:14-17. "I have given them Thy word; and the world hath hated them, because they are not of the world, even as I am not of the world. I pray not that Thou shouldst take them out of the world, but that Thou shouldst keep them from the evil. They are not of the world, even as I am not of the world. Sanctify them through Thy truth: Thy word is truth."

That prayer is known as Jesus' "high priestly prayer," in which He interceded for His disciples and those who would believe in Him after that time. He expressed His desire to protect His followers from the world and from the evil of it. It is a call for all to seek divine guidance, spiritual strength, and God's protection in the chal-

lenges and conflicts that arise. If Jesus prayed for His disciples and for those who would believe in Him throughout all time, we need to pray without ceasing; prayer is the life of the soul.

“We should pray in the family circle, and above all we must not neglect secret prayer; for this is the life of the soul. It is impossible for the soul to flourish while prayer is neglected. Family or public prayer alone is not sufficient. In solitude let the soul be laid open to the inspecting eye of God. Secret prayer is to be heard only by the prayer-hearing God....

“These silent
prayers rise like
precious incense
to the throne of
grace. Satan cannot
overcome him
whose heart is thus
stayed upon God.”

–*God’s Amazing Grace*,
p. 239.

Prayer in the dark prison

When the apostle Paul wrote his letter to the Philippians, he urged them always to be happy, even as he himself was incarcerated in a Roman prison. Despite the danger that he might be sentenced to death, Paul’s attitude in the letter to the Philippians was remarkably optimistic, using words such as “joy” and “rejoicing” about sixteen times. Philippians 1:15-20. How is it possible for a person who is unjustly imprisoned to speak of rejoicing? Philippians 4:11-13 contains the answer: “... I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content. I know both how to be abased, and I know how

to abound: every where and in all things I am instructed both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.”

Sometimes we cannot experience a full connection with God unless we are in extreme situations. I do not know how many times I preached about Paul’s experience in being imprisoned in dungeons and prisons. Then, one day I experienced what it is like to be imprisoned for the sake of supposed justice, with the whole world against you. There is not a single ray of hope, and everything seems lost. And it is in that moment that one understands that the only thing he can do is pray; in the loneliness and darkness of the prison, your mind can rise to the throne of grace, for no prison or dungeon can stop the prayer of faith.

It was in prison that I learned to depend more on God through prayer. Sometimes He allows us to face adverse circumstances so that we can testify of His love. I never imagined that the lawyer who defended me would become a follower of Christ, but the day came when I had the privilege of baptizing him. It reminds me of the experience that the apostle Paul made, along with Silas, in the prison in Philippi. After being whipped with a Roman scourge, put in a dungeon, and chained, it was terrible. Nevertheless, God’s faithful witnesses trusted Him as their only hope. “And at midnight Paul and Silas prayed, and sang praises unto God: and the prisoners heard them.” Acts 16:25.

Yes, the prisoners heard. How many spiritual prisoners around us need to listen to our personal testimonies? What are the spiritual prisons and dungeons that take away one’s freedom to worship God? There may be

doubt, discouragement, pride, bitterness, hatred, or sin; but no matter what it is, cry out to God as the apostle Paul did! Cause an earthquake with your testimony! “And suddenly there was a great earthquake, so that the foundations of the prison were shaken: and immediately all the doors were opened, and every one’s bands were loosed.” Acts 16:26.

“All heaven was interested in the men who were suffering for Christ’s sake, and angels were sent to visit the prison. At their tread the earth trembled. The heavily bolted prison doors were thrown open; the chains and fetters fell from the hands and feet of the prisoners; and a bright light flooded the prison.

“The keeper of the jail had heard with amazement the prayers and songs of the imprisoned apostles. When they were led in, he had seen their swollen and bleeding wounds, and had himself caused their feet to be fastened in the stocks. He had expected to hear from them bitter groans and imprecations, but he heard instead songs of joy and praise. With these sounds in his ears the jailer had fallen into a sleep from which he was awakened by the earthquake and the shaking of the prison walls.”
–*The Acts of the Apostles*, p. 215.

“We are now
standing on the
threshold of great
and solemn events.
A crisis is before
us, such as the
world has never
witnessed.”

–*Thoughts from the
Mount of Blessing*, p. 120.

In short, Paul found good cheer and joy not in external circumstances but in his trust in Christ, who strengthened him to face every favorable or unfavorable circumstance. This explained his ability to write about being joyful even while being unjustly imprisoned and facing the possibility of death. He had a connection with God through prayer.

"The prayers you offer in loneliness, in weariness, in trial, God answers, not always according to your expectations, but always for your good." –*Gospel Workers*, p. 258.

Continual prayer

In the gospel of Luke 21:36, we read: "Watch ye therefore, and pray always, that ye may be accounted worthy to escape all these things that shall come

to pass, and to stand before the Son of man."

"There is no time or place in which it is inappropriate to offer up a petition to God. There is nothing that can prevent us from lifting up our hearts in the spirit of earnest prayer. In the crowds of the street, in the midst of a business engagement, we may send up a petition to God and plead for divine guidance, as did Nehemiah when he made his request before King Artaxerxes. A closet of communion may be found wherever we are. We should have the door of the heart open continually and our invitation going up that Jesus may come and abide as a heavenly guest in the soul." –*Reflecting Christ*, p. 122.

May God help us to understand that prayer is a spiritual tool that we can use anytime. Jesus promised, "Therefore I say unto you, What things soever ye

desire, when ye pray, believe that ye receive them, and ye shall have them." Mark 11:24.

Why does it often seem that our prayers do not reach heaven? Because we have so many heavy burdens that have emotionally damaged us. They make life bitter and take away the joy of our salvation, making us feel as if our prayers are not heard. This is the time to ask for strength in prayer and to look for the person who hurt us or whom we have hurt. "And when ye stand praying, forgive, if ye have ought against any: that your Father also which is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses. But if ye do not forgive, neither will your Father which is in heaven forgive your trespasses." Mark 11:25, 26.

May God forgive us in these final days of the year. Let peace dwell in your hearts through prayer. Amen.

O give thanks unto the Lord; for he is good: for his mercy endureth for ever.

O give thanks unto the God of gods: for his mercy endureth for ever.

O give thanks to the Lord of lords: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him who alone doeth great Wonders: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him that by wisdom made the heavens: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him that stretched out the earth above the waters: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him that made great lights: for his mercy endureth for ever:

The sun to rule by day: for his mercy endureth for ever:

The moon and stars to rule by night: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him that smote Egypt in their firstborn: for his mercy endureth for ever:

And brought out Israel from among them: for his mercy endureth for ever:

With a strong hand, and with a stretched out arm: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him which divided the Red sea into parts: for his mercy endureth for ever:

And made Israel to pass through the midst of it: for his mercy endureth for ever:

But overthrew Pharaoh and his host in the Red sea: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him which led his people through the wilderness: for his mercy endureth for ever.

To him which smote great kings: for his mercy endureth for ever:

And slew famous kings: for his mercy endureth for ever:

Sihon king of the Amorites: for his mercy endureth for ever:

And Og the king of Bashan: for his mercy endureth for ever:

And gave their land for an heritage: for his mercy endureth for ever:

Even an heritage unto Israel his servant: for his mercy endureth for ever.

Who remembered us in our low estate: for his mercy endureth for ever:

And hath redeemed us from our enemies: for his mercy endureth for ever.

Who giveth food to all flesh: for his mercy endureth for ever.

O give thanks unto the God of heaven: for his mercy endureth for ever.

Psalms 136

PRAYER IN THE TIME OF THE END

Tzvetan Petkov, Bulgaria / U.S.A.



“**A**nd when He rose from prayer, He came to the disciples and found them sleeping for sorrow, and He said to them, ‘Why are you sleeping? Rise and pray that you may not enter into temptation.’” Luke 22:45, 46, English Standard Version.

In the garden of Gethsemane, three times Jesus invited His disciples to watch and pray with Him; and three times He found them sleeping. The sleepy condition of the church is reflected in the parable of the ten virgins. They were all virgins. They were dressed in white garments and carried lamps, but all of them fell asleep. Matthew 25:5. The apostle Paul exclaimed: “... Awake, O sleeper, and arise from the dead, and Christ will shine on you.” Ephesians 5:14, English Standard Version. Sister Ellen G. White made a similar appeal: “Awake, my brethren, awake. Seek righteousness, and stand under the

broad shield of Omnipotence. This is your only safety. God calls upon you to seek Him with humility of heart. Read Daniel’s prayer, and see if your experience will stand the test of fire. God will richly bless those who humble themselves before Him.” –*Letters and Manuscripts*, vol. 18 (1903), p. 1.3014.

Prayer is extremely important in order for us to be awake, focused, and concentrated on our mission at the end of time. Having no time and being late in our responsibilities may bring us to the destiny of the five foolish virgins. They came to the door too late. It was shut, and knocking did not help them.

“The five foolish virgins represent the careless, indolent, self-satisfied professor of religion. They have a calm expectation of entering heaven sometime, yet they have not purified their souls by obeying the truth. They understand the theory of truth, but have no vital connection

with God. They trust to feeling, and neglect to search the Scriptures.” –*The Bible Echo*, November 5, 1894.

Midnight visitor

When we think about the end of time, we recall the parable of Jesus illustrating the kingdom of heaven. “Which of you who has a friend will go to him at midnight and say to him, ‘Friend, lend me three loaves, for a friend of mine has arrived on a journey, and I have nothing to set before him’?...” Luke 11:5, 6, English Standard Version.

“Here Christ represents the petitioner as asking that he may give again. He must obtain the bread, else he cannot supply the necessities of a weary, belated wayfarer. Though his neighbor is unwilling to be troubled, he will not desist his pleading; his friend must be relieved; and at last his importunity is rewarded, his wants are supplied.

"In like manner the disciples were to seek blessings from God.... Often they would be thrown into unexpected positions, and would realize their human insufficiency. Souls that were hungering for the bread of life would come to them, and they would feel themselves to be destitute and helpless. They must receive spiritual food, or they would have nothing to impart. But they were not to turn one soul away unfed." —*Christ's Object Lessons*, p. 140.

This is a lesson for everyone who is living at "midnight"—the end of time, when the hunger for truth will be great in the world. Are we ready to give souls bread? Have we obtained a reserve of the heavenly supplies, and have we prepared to be an instrument to bless others? "All heaven is interested in the carrying forward of the work that Christ came to the world to do. Heavenly agencies are opening ways for the light of truth to shine to the dark places of the earth. Angels are waiting to communicate to those who will take hold of the work that has been pointed out to us for years. Shall we not manifest an interest to set in operation ways and means for the opening up of city work? Many opportunities have been lost through neglecting to do this work at once, through failing to go forward in faith." —*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 9, p. 104.

Three loaves

The host asked for nothing but three loaves. The number three appears in other parables of Christ. In the "three measures of meal," the divine recipe described the kingdom of heaven. Jonah was "three days and three nights in the belly of the whale." At the end of time, the three angels' messages need to be given to the world. Sister Ellen G. White wrote: "... I have had precious

opportunities to obtain an experience. I have had an experience in the first, second, and third angels' messages. The angels are represented as flying in the midst of heaven, proclaiming to the world a message of warning, and having a direct bearing upon the people living in the last days of this earth's history. No one hears the voice of these angels, for they are a symbol to represent the people of God who are working in harmony with the universe of heaven. Men and women, enlightened by the Spirit of God and sanctified through the truth, proclaim the three messages in their order." —*Selected Messages*, book 2, p. 387.

As in the parable, we need to obtain the three loaves and give bread to a hungry world. The warning messages are the last hope for humanity, and spreading the warning is of vital importance. "The three angels of Revelation 14 represent the people who accept the light of God's messages and go forth as His agents to sound the warning throughout the length and breadth of the earth.... Talk it, pray it, sing it, fill the world with the message of His truth, and keep pressing on into the regions beyond." —*Counsels for the Church*, p. 58.

Prayer is extremely important in order for us to be awake, focused, and concentrated on our mission at the end of time.

A perishing world

"There is soon to be a tremendous crisis. It is making its way with mighty strides, while the men who ought to be catching

the life-giving message from the word of life and sounding the last warning to a fallen world have put out their spiritual eyesight." —*Letters and Manuscripts*, vol. 20 (1905), p. 1.3514.

One final warning needed to be given to Nineveh before the hand of God would be stretched forth and that city would become as Sodom and Gomorrah. A terrible judgment was looming over the city. Jonah was the prophet who was chosen to sound the alarm and warn the fallen nation. But instead, he decided to run away and then hid in the depths of the ship. "So the shipmaster came to him, and said unto him, What meanest thou, O sleeper? arise, call upon thy God, if so be that God will think upon us, that we perish not." Jonah 1:6.

Prayer in the time of the end is prayer for a perishing world. Millions are living in ignorance and sin, worshiping idols, seeking pleasure, and having no idea of the terrible doom that is coming upon the earth. Movies, news, and entertainment are blinding people's senses. False religions are misleading their followers with false prophecies, doctrines, and hopes. "Now is the time for the last warning to be given. There is a special power in the presentation of the truth at the present time...." —*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 6, p. 16.

Prayer at the end is prayer when there is no more time. "We are nearing the close of this earth's history. We have before us a great work—the closing work of giving the last warning message to a sinful world. There are men who will be taken from the plow, from the vineyard, from various other branches of work, and sent forth by the Lord to give this message to the world." —*Gospel Workers* (1915), p. 36.

Pray earnestly

In the parable, Jesus also emphasized the importance of perseverance in prayer. "I tell you, though he will not get up and give him anything because he is his friend, yet because of his impudence he will rise and give him whatever he needs." Luke 11:8, English Standard Version. "But the selfish neighbor in the parable does not represent the character of God. The lesson is drawn, not by comparison, but by contrast. A selfish man will grant an urgent request, in order to rid himself of one who disturbs his rest. But God delights to give. He is full of compassion, and He longs to grant the requests of those who come unto Him in faith. He gives to us that we may minister to others and thus become like Himself." —*Christ's Object Lessons*, p. 141.

"This lesson means much more than we imagine. We are to keep on asking, even if we do not realize the immediate response to our prayers." —*Letters and Manuscripts*, vol. 7 (1891-1892), p. 1.3753. The promises of the Lord are amazing. "Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you. For everyone who asks receives, and the one who seeks finds, and to the one who knocks it will be

opened." Matthew 7:7, 8, English Standard Version. God is not like the man in the parable, unwilling to give. He gladly answers one's prayer if it is for his spiritual blessing. "What father among you, if his son asks for a fish, will instead of a fish give him a serpent?... If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask Him!" Luke 11:11, 13, English Standard Version.

Perseverance is needed for successful prayer and for receiving an answer. Remember when Elijah the prophet prayed for rain. He prayed not once, not twice, but seven times until the small cloud appeared in the sky. The end of time requires earnest, persevering prayer. "The world's Redeemer spent much time in prayer. He loved the solitude of the mountain, where He could hold communion with His Father alone. We read: 'And when He had sent the multitudes away, He went up into a mountain apart to pray: and when the evening was come, He was there alone.' 'And in the morning, rising up a great while before day, He went out, and departed into a solitary place, and there prayed.' 'He went out into a mountain to pray, and contin-

ued all night in prayer to God.' If Jesus manifested so much earnestness, how much more need for us to wrestle with God, and say, 'I will not let Thee go, except Thou bless me.'" —*The Youth's Instructor*, February 15, 1900.

Jacob's wrestling with God

"It is our privilege to have faith and salvation. The power of God has not decreased. His power, I saw, would be just as freely bestowed now as formerly. It is the church of God that have lost their faith to claim, their energy to wrestle, as did Jacob, crying: 'I will not let Thee go, except Thou bless me.' Enduring faith has been dying away. It must be revived in the hearts of God's people. There must be a claiming of the blessing of God. Faith, living faith, always bears upward to God and glory; unbelief, downward to darkness and death." —*Testimonies for the Church*, vol. 1, p. 144.

Let us awake and pray, let us obtain the bread of life and give it to those around us, let us obtain the necessary experience and be ready for the time of the end. Every soul who is saved from destruction is a victory for Jesus. Amen!



International Missionary Society
Seventh-day Adventist Church,
Reform Movement
General Conference